Prehistoric & Harappan Period

Prehistoric period

- No written records are available
- Development of archaeology and archaeological remains helps much to understand the life and culture of the people who lived in this period
- Archaeological remains- stone tools, pottery, artifacts, and metal implements used by prehistoric people

Dating technique of prehistoric age

- Radio-carbon dating- It is based on measuring the loss of carbon in organic materials over a period of time
- Dendro-Chronology- refers to the number of tree rings in wood. By counting, the number of tree rings in the wood, the date of the wood is arrived at

Famous sites of Old Stone Age (2 mn BCE to 10000 BCE) in India:

- Soan valley and Potwar plateau
- Siwalik hills on the north India
- Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh
- Adamgarh Hills in Narmada Valley
- Kurnool in Andhra Pradesh
- Attirampakkam near Chennai

Characteristic features:

- Hunter gatherers- food was obtained by hunting animals and gathering edible plants and tubers
- They used stone tools, hand-sized and flaked-off large pebbles for hunting animals
- Stone implements are made of a hard rock called quartzite
- Language and communication were not well known
- Their way of life became modified with the passage of time since they made attempts to domesticate animals, male crude pots and grow some plants
- A few Old Stone Age paintings have also been found on rocks at Bhimbetka and other places

Mesolithic or Middle Stone Age (10000 BCE- 6000 BCE)

This is the transitional phase between the paleolithic and neolithic ages.
Famous sites:

- Langhnaj in Gujarat
- Adamgarh in Madhya Pradesh
- Some places of Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar

Characteristic features:

- Paintings and engravings found at the rock shelters give an idea about the social life and economic activities of Mesolithic people
- The hunting gathering pattern of life continued
- Seems to have been a shift from big animal hunting to small ones, and fishing
- Different types of stone tools are found. These are tiny stone artifacts, often more than five centimetres in size, and therefore called microliths
- The use of bow and arrow began in this period
- Tend to settle for longer periods in an area. Therefore, domestication of animals, horticulture and primitive cultivation started
- Animal bones are found in these sites and these include dog, deer, boar and ostrich
- Occasionally, burials of the dead along with some microliths and shells seem to have been practised

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Neolithic age (6000 BCE- 4000 BCE)

Important sites :

- Kashmir valley
- Chirand in Bihar
- Belan valley, UP
- Several places in the Deccan
- South India- Maski, Brahmagiri, Hallur and Kodekal in Karnataka, Paiyampalli in TN and Utnur in Andhra Pradesh

Characteristic features:

- Practice of agriculture, domestication of animals, polishing of stone tools and manufacture of pottery
- Cultivation of plants and domestication of animals led to emergence of village communities based on sedentary life

- Mud brick houses were built instead of grass huts
- Wheels were used to make pottery. Pottery was used for cooking as well as storage of food grains
- There was also improvement in agriculture. Wheat, barley, rice, millet were cultivated. Rice cultivation was extensive in eastern India
- Domestication of sheep, goats and cattle was widely prevalent. Cattle were used for cultivation and for transport
- The people of Neolithic age used clothes made of cotton and wool
- Improvement in technology of making tools and other equipment. Stone tools were now polished for hunting and cutting trees

Metal Age or Chalcolithic (copper-stone) period

- When copper and bronze came to be used. The new technology developed of smelting metal ore and crafting metal artifacts
- But the use of stone tools was not given up. Some of the microlithic tools continued to be essential items
- People began to travel for a long distance to obtain metal ores, that's why Chalcolithic cultures were found in many parts of India
- Chalcolithic cultures had grown in river valleys, Harappan culture is considered part of Chalcolithic culture
- Several bronze and copper objects, terracotta figurines and pottery were found at Paiyampalli in TN

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Iron Age (1200 BCE- 600 BCE)

- The Chalcolithic age is followed by Iron Age
- Iron is frequently referred to in the Vedas
- The Iron Age of the southern peninsula is often related to megalithic burials. Megalith means large stone
- The burial pits were covered with these stones are extensively found in South India

Important megalithic sites :

- Hallur and Maski in Karnataka, Nagarjunakonda in Andhra Pradesh and Adichchanallur in Tamil Nadu
- Black and red pottery, iron artifacts such as hoes and sickles and small weapons were found in the burial pits

The Harappan Civilization

It was first called the Indus Valley Civilization. But later it was named as the Indus Civilization. The earliest excavations in the Indus Valley were done at Harappa in the West Punjab and Mohenjodaro in Sindh (both now in Pakistan)

Origin and Evolution

Gradual development with four important stages or phases of evolution- pre, early, mature and late Harappan phases.

Pre-Harappan stage :

- Located in eastern Balochistan. The excavations at Mehrgarh 150 miles to the northwest of Mohenjodaro reveal the existence of pre Harappan culture
- The nomadic people began to lead a settled agricultural life

Early Harappan stage :

- People lived in large villages in the plains
- There was a gradual growth of towns in the Indus Valley
- Also, the transition from rural to urban life took place during this period
- The sites of Amri and Kot Diji remain the evidence for early Harappan stage

Mature Harappan stage:

- Great cities emerged. The excavations at Kalibangan with its elaborate town planning and urban features prove this phase of evolution

Late Harappan stage:

- Decline of the Indus culture started
- The excavations at Lothal reveal this stage of evolution
- Lothal remained an emporium of trade between the Harappan civilization and the remaining part of India as well as Mesopotamia

Date of Harappan culture:

- The advent of the radiocarbon method paves way for fixing almost accurate dates
- D.P. Agarwal concluded the total span of this culture should be between 2300 and 1750 BCE

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Important sites

- Kot Diji in Sindh
- Kalibangan in Rajasthan
- Rupar in Punjab
- Banawali in Haryana
- Lothal, Surkotada, Dholavira in Gujarat

Salient features of the Harappan Culture

Town planning:

- On the lines of the grid system, that is streets and lanes cutting across one another almost at right angles thus dividing the city into several rectangular blocks
- Harappa, Mohenjodaro and Kalibangan each had its own citadel built on a high podium of mud brick
- Below the citadel in each city lay a lower town containing brick houses, which were inhabited by the common people
- Citadel of Harappa had as many as six granaries

Important characteristics:

- The large scale use of burnt bricks in constructions and the absence of stone buildings
- Another remarkable feature was the underground drainage system connecting all houses to the street drains which were covered by stone slabs or bricks

The Great Bath at Mohenjodaro- the most important public place measuring 39 feet length, 23 feet breadth and 8 feet depth. It must have served as a ritual bathing site. The floor of the bath was made of burnt bricks.

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